also of Chinese perceptions of a world very different from their home country.

There are two notable elements in Ma Huan's account.

One, he testifies to the prosperity and sophistication of Calicut, which he describes as 'the great country of the western ocean', boasting of a mixed population of Hindus and Muslims, although he mistakenly refers to the Hindus as Buddhist. Calicut's trading culture, Ma Huan notes, is based on trust, where contracts arrived at are always upheld and the people 'are very honest and trustworthy. Their appearance is smart, fine and distinguished. Freight ships from every place come here and the king of the country [assigns] a chief and a writer and others to watch the sales, thereupon they collect the duty and pay it to the authorities.' Clearly, this was no 'barbarian' country; rather, it is admired and its ruler is given deference by Zheng He.

Two, despite acknowledging Calicut's prosperity and status, Ma Huan explains that the second of Zheng He's voyages to the kingdom was for the purpose of delivering 'an imperial mandate to the king of this country and to bestow on him a patent conferring a title of honour, and the grant of a silver seal, (also) to promote all the chiefs and award them hats and girdles of various grades'.

This testifies to the political nature of Zheng He's voyages: to assert Ming overlordship, ceremonial though this may have been, over the various countries across the oceans with which China maintained significant trade relations. Trade and politics went together and both reinforced China's sense of centrality in what today is called the Indo-Pacific.

The present Chinese narrative seeks to present these voyages as examples of its seeking friendly relations with the countries visited by Zheng He and to promote mutually beneficial trade. They were actually designed to convey what today may be called 'shock and awe'. The voyages were not only motivated by reasons of trade although they did engage in trade. They were warships carrying nearly 30,000 crew, most being armed soldiers. The ships had cannons and these were used against recalcitrant rulers. This aspect too is clearly conveyed in the Ming Shu, the chronicle of the Ming